



Aliens in UAE?

UAE's new building for environmental management looks no less than an alien spacecraft, docked in the middle of the desert <http://dgit.in/AlienStruc>



Salmon shooting

Whoosh built a cannon system that shoots off Salmon over a dam. Here's to the future of ecological conservation <http://dgit.in/Whooshh>

Bazaar

iBall Slide WQ149

A decent enough tablet that's hampered by poor design

Microsoft's vision for its Windows platform is a bit, well, fuzzy. Windows 8 and the Surface series of PCs/Tablets were designed with "work" tablets in mind, to create a device and platform that was as good for work as it was for entertainment. The initial Surface RT devices failed because they seemed to represent the worst of both worlds, presenting users with a cross between a somewhat more powerful netbook and an app-less tablet that only really offered Word and IE.

What those devices did bring, however, was incredibly good design. Despite their many flaws, the Surface series is among the most thoughtfully designed tablet PCs available today and you do have to commend its design.

The iBall Slide is, in a way, the antithesis to the Surface's design. By itself, it's a good enough tablet. For ₹25,000, you get an Intel Bay Trail powered device with a nice screen, decent speakers, Windows 8.1 and a nice touch screen. You also get a nice pouch to carry the device, and a charger as well.

On the downside, you only get 32GB of HDD space, 10GB of which is hogged by your OS, a micro-SD card reader (so you can't plug-in your camera's SD card) and a micro-USB port (with full-size adapter), along with a keyboard cover, which is what this device is really about but isn't very good.

While using the device as just a tablet, browsing and watching movies, it seemed fine, only really suffering from the problems that Windows 8 itself presents rather than any issue with the hardware. 20GB of usable HDD space is very low, but if you're used to tablets and mobile devices in general, you won't notice the shortfall since it's not meant to be a primary computing device anyway.

It's when you decide to actually start working on the device that the frustrations begin. Firstly, the keyboard cover is awkward. It's been designed to envelop the device, but only latches on in the middle via a magnetic clip not unlike the one on the Surface. The problem is that both sides hang free and neither of them latch onto either the front or the back of the tablet. To compound this problem, the rear flap is hinged at two more points diagonally, meaning that you can never hold the cover flush against the rear of the device.

The keyboard itself is actually quite nice to type on, but while the Surface managed to find an elegant solution to "lapability" (working with the



device on your lap), the Slide's solution is clunky, fiddlesome and rarely worth the effort, while also being limited to one angle.

If you're familiar with an iPad's cover, opening and closing it unlocks and locks the device. This isn't the case here and this is a serious problem because the power button sticks out the side and is easy to press, resulting in the device turning on randomly even while in your bag. It was this same problem that caused the device to overheat badly and the battery to discharge completely on more than one occasion.

Speaking of the battery, our tests were entirely inconclusive. The device gave us battery life ranging from 2.5 hours to five hours at max. brightness (PCMark 8 Work test) and this was never consistent. Going by the results however, we can estimate a battery life of at least 3-4 hours for regular use.

Worse still is the implementation of the USB port. Half the reason anyone would want a Windows-based tablet is for the freedom that it offers, but with only one micro-USB port (USB 2.0) and virtually no on-board storage, you have to carry around the adapter if you want to plug in a USB drive or HDD. If that wasn't enough of a problem, the device takes forever to charge and even then, charges via that lone USB port, rendering it useless for everything else.

The iBall slide is a great example of the power and flexibility of Intel's BayTrail platform, but it also underscores the need for good design. Till the more serious flaws in its design are fixed, particularly with regards to the keyboard cover, we just cannot recommend this device.

Anirudh Regidi



Features 57
Performance 75
Design 30
Value for money 45

Specifications

CPU: Intel Atom Z3735D;
RAM: 2Gb; **HDD:** 32GB;
Display: 10.1" @ 1280x800;
Battery: 31.8Wh; **3G**
Network: WCDMA 2100MHz
(Data only); **Connectivity:**
Wi-Fi 802.11 b/g/n. Micro
USB, Mini HDMI, **Bluetooth**
4.0, Pogo Pin k/b interface;
Misc: One year, one user
Office 365 license with 1TB
SkyDrive space

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